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NEW
2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Paper 1

Practice Pack

Three complete Paper 1 Reading practice papers in the new 2027 format, each with original texts, a full question paper and a detailed mark scheme.

- ◆ 3 full practice papers (240 marks)
- ◆ All four 20-mark questions
- ◆ 2-mark word-meaning questions
- ◆ Marking bands for writing
- ◆ 9 original reading texts
- ◆ New Q2(b) attitudes question
- ◆ Indicative content for every task
- ◆ Student score tracker

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For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All texts are original.

How to use this pack

Each practice set follows the structure of the Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 1 Reading exam from June 2027: three texts, four compulsory questions of 20 marks each, 80 marks in total, 2 hours.

Question	Text	Task	Marks
Q1	A	Comprehension: explicit and implicit meaning	20
Q2(a)	B	Summary, max 120 words	15
Q2(b)	B	Writer's attitudes and opinions	5
Q3	C	Short answers incl. 2-mark word meanings	10
Q3	C	Language task, 200–250 words	10
Q4	C	Extended response, 250–300 words	20

Three ways to use it

Full mock

Print the insert and question paper. Set a strict 2-hour timer. Mark with the scheme and record scores on the tracker.

Question by question

Use one question as a lesson or homework. Mark it together, then rewrite the weakest answer.

Tutoring & intervention

Diagnose with Set 1, teach the weakest skill, and use Sets 2 and 3 to measure progress.

Suggested timing (120 minutes)

Read all texts 15 min · Q1 20 min · Q2 25 min · Q3 25 min · Q4 30 min · Check 5 min. Each question is worth the same 20 marks, so don't let one question take time from the next.

BEFORE YOU MARK: The mark schemes give indicative content, not a list of the only right answers. Credit any valid point that is clearly rooted in the text.

Contents

Practice Set 1	The Sea
Practice Set 2	Work and Challenge
Practice Set 3	Endings and Beginnings
Marking guidance	Bands for Q2(a) writing, Q3 language task and Q4
Score tracker	Record and compare results across all three sets

PRACTICE SET 1

The Sea

TEXT A The Last Pearl (*fiction*)

TEXT B The Quiet Crisis Beneath the Waves (*magazine article*)

TEXT C Crossing to Musandam (*travel memoir*)

Insert: about 1,230 words · Question paper · Mark scheme

The Last Pearl

Fiction

- 1 Salem had imagined this morning so many times that the real thing felt slightly wrong, like a photograph printed in the wrong colours. The sea was not the bright blue of his daydreams but a flat, milky green, and the dhow smelled of diesel and old rope rather than adventure.
- 2 His grandfather sat at the stern, one hand resting on the tiller as lightly as if it were a sleeping cat. Jaddi had not dived for pearls in fifty years, but he still read the water the way other men read newspapers, frowning at a ripple here, nodding at a darker patch there.
- 3 “Here,” he said at last, and cut the engine.
- 4 The silence arrived all at once. Salem could hear the hull creak and the slap of small waves and, somewhere beneath it all, his own heart, which seemed to have climbed into his throat.
- 5 “You don’t have to,” Jaddi said, without looking at him.
- 6 “I want to.” It came out louder than Salem intended.
- 7 His grandfather handed him a nose clip carved from turtle shell – the same one, he said, that he had worn as a boy – and a stone tied to a length of rope. “The stone takes you down. The rope brings you back. Your job is only to keep your eyes open.”
- 8 Salem clipped his nose, filled his lungs and let the stone pull him under.
- 9 For the first few seconds it was wonderful. The noise of the world switched off. Sunlight fell through the water in long, trembling ribbons, and the seabed rose to meet him, scattered with shells and the slow grey shapes of oysters. Then the pressure began to squeeze his ears, a voice inside him began to count, faster and faster, and suddenly the whole weight of the Gulf seemed to be pressing on his chest.
- 10 He tugged the rope twice, as he had been taught, and kicked frantically for the light.
- 11 He broke the surface gasping, eyes stinging, certain he had failed. But his grandfather was leaning over the side, and he was laughing – not unkindly, but with a kind of delight Salem had never seen on his face.
- 12 “Four metres,” Jaddi said. “The first time I went down, I reached two, and I cried for my mother.” He reached out a hand, rough as rope. “Again tomorrow?”
- 13 Salem looked at the water, which no longer seemed flat or ordinary. “Again tomorrow,” he said.

The Quiet Crisis Beneath the Waves

Magazine article

- 1 Coral reefs cover less than one per cent of the ocean floor, yet they are home to around a quarter of all marine species. Divers often describe them as underwater cities and, like cities, they are busy, crowded and surprisingly fragile.
- 2 The greatest threat is heat. When the sea stays too warm for too long, corals expel the tiny algae that live inside them and give them both their colour and most of their food. The coral turns white – ‘bleached’ – and, if the water does not cool, it slowly starves. Some reefs in the Gulf, which already survive in some of the hottest seas on Earth, have lost large areas of coral during recent summers.
- 3 Heat is not the only problem. As the ocean absorbs more carbon dioxide from the air, it becomes more acidic, which makes it harder for corals to build their stony skeletons. Closer to shore, construction and dredging stir up sediment that blocks the light corals need. Fertiliser washed off farmland feeds algae that smother reefs, while careless anchoring and overfishing upset the delicate balance of life that keeps a reef healthy. Even sunscreen, in popular bays, may add to the stress.
- 4 It would be easy to give up. Yet scientists and volunteers are refusing to do so. In nurseries on the seabed, fragments of healthy coral are grown on frames like seedlings in a garden and then replanted on damaged reefs. Researchers are breeding corals that can tolerate warmer water. Marine protected areas, where fishing and anchoring are restricted, give reefs time to recover, and in several of them fish numbers have risen sharply within a few years.
- 5 Some of the most important work is also the least glamorous. Every week, volunteer divers count fish, photograph coral and record which colonies have bleached. Their patient, unpaid data allows scientists to spot problems early. Many of these volunteers are ordinary office workers and students who simply cannot bear to watch something beautiful disappear. They are, in their quiet way, heroes.
- 6 None of this will be enough on its own. Unless the world cuts the emissions that are heating the oceans, reefs will keep bleaching faster than they can be repaired. But the people rebuilding them, fragment by fragment, are buying precious time – and reminding the rest of us that what has been damaged can still be saved.

Crossing to Musandam

Travel memoir

- 1 We left Dibba just after dawn, when the sea was so **placid** that the ferry seemed to be sliding across a sheet of polished pewter. The mountains of Musandam rose ahead of us, brown and bare and folded like crumpled paper, and my brother Karim, who had planned the whole trip, stood at the rail naming every headland as if he had built it himself.
- 2 The change came without warning. One moment the horizon was a clean, sharp line; the next it had vanished behind a bruised purple wall of cloud that swallowed the mountains one by one. The wind arrived first, snatching Karim's cap and flinging it into the wake. Then the sea itself woke up. Waves that had been lazy ripples reared into grey, white-crested ridges, and the ferry began to climb each one with a groan, hang for a sickening second at the top, and then plunge into the trough beyond.
- 3 Inside the cabin, bags slid across the floor. A tray of tea glasses lurched off the counter and exploded like fireworks. An elderly woman beside me closed her eyes and moved her lips silently, and a small boy stopped crying and simply stared, which was somehow worse.
- 4 Through the salt-streaked window, the world had turned to chaos. Rain came sideways, hammering the glass like a thousand impatient fists. Spray burst over the bow in great white explosions, and each time the ferry buried its nose in a wave, the whole vessel shuddered as though it had been struck. Only the captain seemed unmoved. I could see him on the bridge above us, his hands steady on the wheel, staring **resolutely** ahead as if the storm were an argument he fully intended to win.
- 5 It lasted perhaps forty minutes. Then, as suddenly as it had come, the cloud tore open and a shaft of sunlight fell across the water like a spotlight on a stage. The waves sank back into a gentle swell. Someone began to laugh with relief, and soon the whole cabin was laughing – at the broken glasses, at our soaked clothes, at Karim, who had lost not only his cap but, for once, his voice.
- 6 We reached Khasab two hours late. As the ferry nosed into the harbour, I noticed the captain step out onto the deck and pour himself a glass of water with hands that, now it was over, were trembling. I have thought about those hands many times since. The storm had been humbling: it reminded us how little we control, and how much we depend on the calm courage of strangers.

Paper 1 Reading • Practice Set 1

2 hours • 80 marks. Answer **all** questions. The texts are in the insert (Texts A, B and C). Spend about 15 minutes reading before you write. Dictionaries are not allowed.

Question 1 *Text A: The Last Pearl*

- (a) Give **two** ways in which the real morning was different from Salem's daydreams. [2]
- (b) Re-read paragraph 2. [2]
 - (i) What does the comparison "as lightly as if it were a sleeping cat" suggest about how Jaddi steers the boat?
 - (ii) Explain what the writer means by "he still read the water the way other men read newspapers". [2]
- (c) How does Salem feel when the engine is cut? Support your answer with a detail from the text. [2]
- (d) "It came out louder than Salem intended." What does this suggest about Salem at this moment? [2]
- (e) Why do you think the nose clip is important to Jaddi? [2]
- (f) Using your own words, explain what Jaddi tells Salem his only job is, and why he only has one job. [2]
- (g) Re-read paragraph 9 ("For the first few seconds..."). Explain how Salem's experience changes during the dive. [3]
- (h) Why does Salem feel "certain he had failed", and why is he wrong? Use your own words. [3]

Total for Question 1: [20]

Question 2 *Text B: The Quiet Crisis Beneath the Waves*

- (a) According to Text B, what threatens coral reefs **and** what is being done to protect them? [15]
You must use continuous writing (not note form) and your own words as far as possible. Your summary should not be more than **120 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 5 marks for the quality of your writing.
- (b) What is the writer's attitude towards the volunteers who help protect reefs? Explain how you can tell. [5]

Total for Question 2: [20]

Question 3 *Text C: Crossing to Musandam*

- (a) Using your own words, explain what the following words mean as they are used in the text: [2]
 - (i) **placid** (paragraph 1)
 - (ii) **resolutely** (paragraph 4) [2]
- (b) Re-read paragraph 1. What impression does the writer give of Karim? Refer to **two** details. [2]
- (c) Re-read paragraph 3. Why does the writer think the small boy's silence "was somehow worse" than his crying? [2]

- (d) Re-read paragraph 6. What do the captain's trembling hands reveal about him? [2]
- (e) Re-read paragraphs 2 and 4. Explain how the writer uses language to convey the power of the storm and people's reactions to it. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph and explain how they are used effectively. Write about **200 to 250 words**. [10]

Total for Question 3: [20]

Question 4 *Text C: Crossing to Musandam*

Imagine you are Karim. That evening in Khasab you write a letter to a friend about the journey. [20]

In your letter you should:

- describe the journey before and during the storm
- explain how the other passengers and the captain behaved
- reflect on what you learned about yourself and other people from the experience.

Base your letter on what you have read in Text C, but be careful to use your own words.

Address each of the three bullet points. Begin your letter appropriately. Write about **250 to 300 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 10 marks for the quality of your writing.

Total for Question 4: [20]

Mark scheme • Practice Set 1

Accept any valid alternative that is rooted in the text. Answers must be in the candidate's own words where the question says so.

Question 1 20 marks

(a)	Any two: the sea was not bright blue but <i>milky green</i> (1); it was <i>flat</i> / not exciting (1); the dhow smelled of <i>diesel</i> and <i>old rope</i> , not adventure (1).	2
(b)(i)	He steers gently / with little effort (1); he is relaxed, calm or confident, so steering comes naturally from experience (1).	2
(b)(ii)	He can still understand / interpret the sea easily (1), because of long experience; he reads signs in the water such as ripples and colour as naturally as an everyday habit (1).	2
(c)	Nervous / frightened / tense (1) + evidence: his heart "seemed to have climbed into his throat" (1).	2
(d)	He is trying to sound braver or more certain than he feels (1); he may be trying to convince himself / prove himself to his grandfather (1).	2
(e)	It is a link to his own past as a diver / he wore it as a boy (1); passing it on shows pride, trust or a wish to continue the family tradition (1).	2
(f)	His only job is to keep looking / stay alert / observe (1); the stone and rope do the work of taking him down and bringing him back (1).	2
(g)	Up to 3: at first peaceful and amazing – the noise stops, beautiful light and seabed (1); then physical discomfort – pressure squeezes his ears (1); then rising panic – counting faster, feels crushed / overwhelmed by the weight of water (1).	3
(h)	Up to 3: he panicked / came up early / surfaced gasping (1); but his grandfather is delighted / laughing with pleasure (1); four metres is further than his grandfather's first dive of two metres / he is invited to dive again, showing approval (1).	3

Question 2(a) 15 marks = 10 Reading + 5 Writing

Reading: award 1 mark per relevant point, up to 10. **Writing:** use the Summary Writing bands on the Marking Guidance page.

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1. sea temperatures stay too high for too long | 9. overfishing upsets the reef's balance |
| 2. corals lose / expel the algae that give colour and food, so they bleach | 10. sunscreen may add stress in busy bays |
| 3. bleached corals starve if the water stays warm | 11. coral fragments grown in underwater nurseries and replanted |
| 4. carbon dioxide makes the ocean more acidic | 12. breeding corals that tolerate heat |
| 5. acidity makes it harder for corals to build skeletons | 13. protected areas limit fishing and anchoring so reefs recover |
| 6. coastal building / dredging creates sediment that blocks light | 14. volunteers monitor / record reef health so problems are spotted early |
| 7. fertiliser run-off feeds algae that smother reefs | 15. (ultimately) the world needs to cut emissions |
| 8. careless anchoring damages reefs | |

Question 2(b) 5 marks

Award 1 mark per developed point (attitude + evidence + brief explanation), up to 5. Indicative content:

- Admiring / sees them as heroic: "They are, in their quiet way, heroes."
- Respects their dedication: their work is "patient" and "unpaid".
- Values their importance: "some of the most important work", allowing problems to be spotted early.
- Sympathetic / shares their feelings: they "cannot bear to watch something beautiful disappear".
- Hopeful because of them: they are "buying precious time".

Question 3 short answers 10 marks

(a)(i)	Calm / still / undisturbed / peaceful (2). Award 1 for a partial meaning, e.g. "quiet".	2
(a)(ii)	Determinedly / firmly / with unwavering purpose (2). Award 1 for "bravely" or "seriously".	2
(b)	Enthusiastic / proud / a bit of a know-it-all (1) + detail: he planned the whole trip; he named every headland "as if he had built it himself" (1).	2
(c)	Silence suggests shock or terror too deep for tears (1); it makes the danger feel real / unsettles the adults (1).	2
(d)	He had been frightened too but hid it (1); his calm was courage / self-control rather than an absence of fear (1).	2

Question 3 language task 10 marks

Mark with the Language Task bands. Indicative content. Reward any well-explained choice; do not reward technique-spotting without explanation.

Paragraph 2

- "without warning" / "one moment... the next" – suddenness, no time to prepare.
- "bruised purple wall of cloud" – "bruised" suggests injury / violence; "wall" – solid, impassable, trapping.
- "swallowed the mountains one by one" – the storm as a monster devouring even huge, solid things.
- "snatching... flinging" – aggressive, careless verbs; the wind as a thief or bully.
- "the sea itself woke up" – personified; a sleeping giant becoming dangerous.
- "reared" – like a wild animal / horse; "climb... hang for a sickening second... plunge" – rhythm mimics the ferry's motion and the stomach-lurching fear.

Paragraph 4

- "the world had turned to chaos" – total loss of order and control.
- "hammering the glass like a thousand impatient fists" – relentless, violent, as if trying to break in; the passengers feel besieged.
- "great white explosions" – continues the language of violence and war.
- "buried its nose" / "shuddered as though it had been struck" – the ferry as a wounded living thing; fragility against the storm.
- "Only the captain seemed unmoved... steady... resolutely" – contrast; his stillness highlights the chaos and reassures.
- "an argument he fully intended to win" – the storm as an opponent; the captain's quiet, stubborn confidence.

Question 4 20 marks = 10 Reading + 10 Writing

Mark with the Extended Response bands. Form conventions for a letter: greeting, clear purpose in the opening, suitable sign-off; informal register to a friend. Indicative content:

Bullet 1. Calm start – smooth, silvery sea; bare mountains; Karim's pride in the trip he planned and enjoyment of naming headlands; sudden purple cloud; cap snatched by the wind; huge waves, the ferry climbing and plunging; rain, spray, shuddering.

Bullet 2. Bags sliding, glasses smashing; the elderly woman praying silently with eyes closed; the boy falling silent and staring; the captain steady, determined, apparently unmoved; relief and laughter afterwards; the captain's trembling hands at Khasab.

Bullet 3 (inference – best answers develop this). Karim was lost for words – perhaps humbled or embarrassed after being so confident; he may feel responsible for planning the trip; realises how little control people have; admires the captain's hidden fear and courage; values his sibling / the shared laughter; may see humour in losing his cap and his voice.

Marking guidance

These bands are written for this pack to support consistent practice marking. They follow the published assessment objectives but are not official Cambridge descriptors. Choose the band that best fits, then the mark within it.

Summary writing *Q2(a) · 5 marks*

5	Wholly relevant, concise and well organised; ideas skilfully grouped and linked; consistently own words.
4	Mostly focused and fluent; ideas clearly organised; mostly own words.
3	Generally clear; some repetition, lifting or loosely relevant material; some attempt to organise.
1–2	Limited clarity; much lifting, listing or note form; may be over-long or include opinion.
0	Wholly copied or no relevant response.

Language task *Q3 · 10 marks*

9–10	A wide range of precise, well-chosen selections from both paragraphs; detailed, perceptive explanation of meaning and effect, including connotations; links to the writer's overall purpose.
7–8	A good range of relevant choices; clear explanations of connotations and effects, several developed.
5–6	Some appropriate choices; explanations generally accurate but sometimes general or uneven between paragraphs.
3–4	Limited selection; some meanings explained; effects vague, or mainly technique labels.
1–2	Few choices; largely repeats the text or labels devices with no explanation.

Extended response *Q4 · 10 Reading + 10 Writing*

	Reading (10)	Writing (10)
9–10	All three bullets addressed thoroughly; ideas developed with convincing, text-based inferences; a sustained, credible voice.	Confident, fluent style; register and form fully appropriate; well-structured; wide vocabulary; highly accurate.
7–8	All bullets addressed; some development and inference beyond the text's surface.	Clear, varied style; appropriate register; well organised; mostly accurate.
5–6	Relevant ideas for each bullet but mainly retold; occasional inference.	Generally clear; some sense of form and audience; errors do not impede meaning.
3–4	Uneven coverage; relies on retelling or lifting; one bullet thin or missing.	Simple style; limited structure; errors sometimes distract.
1–2	Little relevant use of the text.	Frequent errors; little control of form or register.

NEXT STEP

Want the method behind every answer?

The **IGCSE 0500 Complete Exam Guide (2027)** covers both papers question by question, with step-by-step frameworks, weak vs strong model answers, command words, timing plans and the top 10 mark-losing mistakes. It pairs with this pack: learn the method in the guide, then practise it here.

The **IGCSE 0500 Paper 2 Directed Writing Pack (2027)** gives four complete Section A tasks – speech, letter, article and report – with annotated model answers.

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